DAAT TEVUNOT: THE RAMHAL ON CREATION, GOOD AND EVIL, AND THE SOUL

Why Is Judgment Good for the World?

Daat Tevunot §142

Sefer: Daat Tevunot by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Sections:** §142 **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's series on Daat Tevunot, Thursday 29 June 2023

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Judgment is not a negative word

The class began part 2 of Section 7. The Rabbi reviewed that Hashem runs the world in two main ways: the mode of mishpat, judgment and consequences, and the exalted mode in which He does not necessarily judge by our deeds. We also learned that everything is first "conceived" before it is "born".

Now the Ramhal turns to the mode of mishpat, and the Rabbi gave a warning. We tend to think of judgment as something bad. Here we learn that judgment is something good. When there is no judgment, that is usually the negative situation.

The world needs justice

The Sekhel says (§142) that the existence of this world during the 6,000 years, the time for our work, depends on Hashem's judgment. The world can only reach its perfection when justice is done. The Ramhal brings verses: "Hashem is known by the judgment He executes", "Hashem is exalted through justice", "a king establishes the land through justice".

If Hashem left the world without judgment, the wicked would go their way, the righteous would be oppressed and evil would win. That is not good. Judgment restores accountability: it humbles the wicked and raises the righteous, and "when the wicked perish there is joy".

When Hashem "sleeps"

The time when Hashem lets the wicked prosper unchecked is called, regarding Hashem, sleep. When He brings justice again it is said, "Hashem awoke as one who sleeps, like a warrior".

If there were no sins at all, as the verse says, "may sins cease from the earth" (sins, not sinners), the world could be run with kindness alone, and Hashem could, as it were, "sleep". But in the world as it is, sleep is bad. If Hashem waits until the wicked bring about their own ruin, the world grows more and more chaotic in the meantime. That is why "whom Hashem loves He chastises", and "only you have I known of all the nations, therefore I will visit upon you all your sins". Small corrections along the way prevent a build-up that would need a much bigger response.

A lesson from school

The Rabbi told a story from his own school days. He had been misbehaving and told a teacher he would be missing some lessons. The teacher just said, "Fine." The young Rabbi asked whether he was going to try to persuade him to come. The teacher said no: "Sometimes the biggest punishment is that I ignore you and you do what you want." The Rabbi said he never forgot it.

So when Hashem ignores the wicked, they may seem to be doing well, but it builds and builds until it all comes down on them. Meanwhile everyone else suffers from the chaos. That is why we need Hashem to step in with mishpat.

The catch-22 and mode two

The Ramhal continues. With constant judgment, bad would be wiped away as it appears, the world would be put right and everyone would be content. But when there is no merit, Hashem says "I will hide My face". Darkness and foolishness grow, truth is thrown to the ground, and "there is no day whose curse is not greater than the day before", until even the taste of fruit is lost. (The Rabbi joked that English tomatoes have no taste nowadays, "I don't know if that's because of this.")

So it is a kind of catch-22. A little bad and Hashem steps in to correct it. A great deal of bad and He steps back, and with no mishpat things get worse. By the rules of mode one, the world would then deserve to be destroyed. But Hashem wants it to exist. So He keeps it going at a basic, minimal level through the second mode, His sovereignty, which does not look at good or bad at all. The Rabbi compared it to being stung by a bee again and again. You can ignore it for a while, but at some point you have to act.

This explains how the wicked can seem to prosper even more. Under mode one there is too much bad to judge, and under mode two "you're not a sinner", because that mode does not see sin. But mode two only gives bare existence and is meant to be a short-term boost. Left for too long, evil would keep growing. In the end mishpat has to return. Meanwhile, says the Ramhal, the wicked rule with arrogance "like a wild beast in the forest", with no one asking questions.

Two kinds of suspended judgment

The Rabbi ended by heading off a confusion. On Rosh Hashanah and Yom Kippur we ask Hashem to suspend judgment. That is a different kind of suspension. Here the suspension comes from not caring, from hester panim. On the Yamim Noraim we ask for a suspension that comes from love, like a parent whose child has done something wrong but who looks at that face and "just can't punish you, I love you so much".

Summary

- Mishpat, consequences for our deeds, is good for the world. Without it the wicked prosper and chaos grows.
- When Hashem withholds judgment it is called "sleep", and the wicked are left to build up their own downfall while others suffer.

- Too much bad leads Hashem to step back, and then the world survives only through the second mode at a bare minimum.
- The second mode ignores sin, so it can only be a short-term measure, and mishpat must return.
- Suspending judgment out of indifference is hester panim. Suspending it out of love is what we ask for on the Yamim Noraim.

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